

Chapter 8 — Eighteenth-Century Political Formations

The one-line point: Between **Aurangzeb's death (1707)** and the **third battle of Panipat (1761)**, the Mughal Empire dissolved into successor states — Rajputs, Sikhs, Marathas, Jats, Awadh, Bengal, Hyderabad. **And into that gap walked the British.** This chapter is the bridge to Class 8.

← Ch.7 | Index | Next: Ch.9 Supplement →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval → Early Modern India (the transition)
Sub-discipline	Political history — imperial decline and successor states
Period	★ 1707 (Aurangzeb's death) – 1761 (third battle of Panipat)
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → successor states, Maratha administration, Sikh organisation
Mains (GS Paper I)	★★★ Causes of Mughal decline — a standard question; also the setting for British expansion
Also feeds	Modern India ★★★ (this is the immediate prelude to Class 8, Ch.2 "From Trade to Territory"), Polity (federal/regional power), Art & Culture (Jaipur, Dig, forts, Jantar Mantar)
Weightage	★★★★ — high, and rising because it explains how the British won
Overlaps with	Ch.4 (the crisis begins there), Ch.6 (the Khalsa), Class 8 Ch.2 (what happens next)

 **This is the hinge chapter of the entire NCERT History sequence.** Everything before it is "medieval"; everything after is "modern". **Read it as the setup for Class 8.**

Learning Outcomes

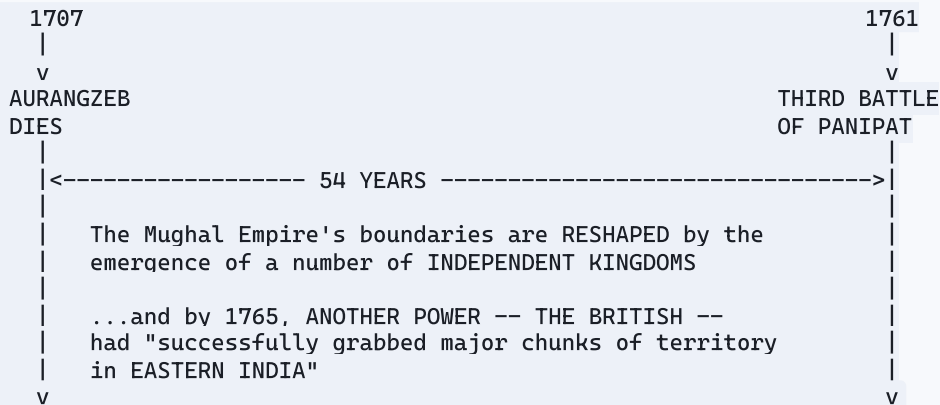
By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **State the period** this chapter covers and why those two dates bound it. ★
- ☐ **List** the causes of the Mughal crisis — Deccan wars, *subadar* consolidation, revenue failure, peasant and zamindar revolts. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** why **combining *diwani* and *faujdari*** in one office was so dangerous. ★★
- ☐ **Describe** the **Nadir Shah (1739)** and **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invasions with dates. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** the **Irani–Turani** factionalism and what it did to the emperors. ★
- ☐ **Classify** the successor states into **three types**. ★★
- ☐ **Describe** the Rajput states — Amber, Jodhpur, ***watan jagir***, **Sawai Jai Singh** and the **Jantar Mantar**. ★★
- ☐ **Narrate** Sikh political organisation — **Banda Bahadur**, ***jathas****, ***misls***, ***dal khalsa***, ***gurmata***, ****rakhi***, **Ranjit Singh**. ★★★
- ☐ **Describe** the Maratha state — **Shivaji**, ***deshmukhs***, ***kunbis***, the **Peshwas**, and **chaauth and sardeshmukhi**. ★★★

- ☐ **Explain** why the Marathas were **isolated at Panipat in 1761**. ★★
- ☐ **Describe** the Jats — **Churaman, Suraj Mal, Bharatpur, Dig.** ★
- ☐ **Assess** whether the 18th century was one of "decline" or of **regional reorganisation**. ★★★



Start Here: The Fifty-Four Years That Decided Everything



★ **Hold those three dates together: 1707, 1761, 1765.** Aurangzeb dies; the Marathas are broken at Panipat; and within four years the British hold Bengal. **The chapter's own maps make exactly this argument.**

🔗 **1765 is the Diwani of Bengal** — the subject of **Class 8, Chapter 2 and 3**. This chapter ends precisely where the next book begins.

1 ★★ ★ The Crisis of the Empire

The causes — learn these as a chain, not a list

- [1] AURANGZEB'S DECCAN WAR
"Emperor Aurangzeb had DEPLETED THE MILITARY AND FINANCIAL RESOURCES of his empire by fighting a LONG WAR IN THE DECCAN."
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- [2] ADMINISTRATIVE BREAKDOWN UNDER HIS SUCCESSORS
"the efficiency of the imperial administration BROKE DOWN"
-> increasingly difficult to keep a check on powerful MANSABDARS
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v
- [3] *** THE FUSION OF OFFICES *** <-- the key structural failure
Nobles appointed as GOVERNORS (SUBADARS) often controlled the offices of REVENUE and MILITARY administration (*** DIWANI and FAUJDARI ***) AS WELL.
-> "This gave them EXTRAORDINARY POLITICAL, ECONOMIC AND MILITARY POWERS over vast regions."
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- [4] REVENUE STOPS FLOWING TO THE CENTRE
"As the governors consolidated their control over the provinces, the PERIODIC REMISSION OF REVENUE TO THE CAPITAL DECLINED."
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v
- [5] PEASANT AND ZAMINDARI REBELLIONS in northern and western India -- caused by MOUNTING TAXES, or by CHIEFTAINS consolidating their own positions.
*** These groups were now able to SEIZE THE ECONOMIC RESOURCES of the region. ***
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- RESULT: the emperors after Aurangzeb were UNABLE TO ARREST
"the gradual shifting of POLITICAL AND ECONOMIC AUTHORITY into the hands of PROVINCIAL GOVERNORS, LOCAL CHIEFTAINS and other groups."

★★★ Point [3] is the one to understand properly, and it wins marks.

The Mughal design deliberately **separated powers**: the *subadar* governed, the *diwan* collected revenue, the *faujdar* commanded troops — three officers watching one another. When a **single noble came to hold all three**, the province acquired **its own money, its own army, and its own government**, answerable to nobody.

🖥️ **A separation-of-duties control collapsed.** The centre had built the safeguard and then allowed the roles to be combined — after which nothing prevented a governor from simply becoming a king. **He did not need to rebel; he only had to stop remitting.**

🔗 **Compare Ch.3:** the Delhi Sultans **rotated muqtis**, made *iqtas* **non-inheritable**, and **audited** them precisely to prevent this. The Mughals let the controls lapse — and lost the empire the Sultans' design had protected.

💰 ★ "Rich harvests and empty coffers"

A contemporary writer on the empire's financial bankruptcy — a superb, quotable passage:

"The great lords are **helpless and impoverished**. Their peasants raise **two crops a year**, but their lords see **nothing of either**, and their agents on the spot are **virtual prisoners in the peasants' hands**... So complete is the collapse of all order and administration that **though the peasant reaps a harvest of gold, his lord does not see so much as a wisp of straw**. How then can the lord **keep the armed force** he should?"

🎯 This is not an agricultural crisis — it is a **COLLECTION crisis**. Production was fine; **extraction had failed**. The state's problem was never that there was no wealth, but that it could **no longer reach it**.

★ And note the closing logic — **no revenue means no army**, which means still less revenue. **The circle of justice (Ch.3) running backwards**. Deploy that link; it is a genuinely elegant connection between two chapters.

🗡️ ★ ★ The invasions

Invader	From	When	What happened
★ ★ NADIR SHAH	Ruler of IRAN	★ 1739	Sacked and plundered DELHI and took away immense amounts of wealth
★ ★ AHMAD SHAH ABDALI	Afghan ruler	★ Five times between 1748 and 1761	A series of plundering raids on north India

★ **What Nadir Shah took**, per a contemporary account:

"Sixty lakhs of rupees and some thousand gold coins, nearly **one crore worth of gold-ware**, nearly **fifty crores worth of jewels**, most of them unrivalled in the world — and the above included the **PEACOCK THRONE**."

And the effect on Delhi:

*"Those who had been masters were now in dire straits... **The wealthy were turned into beggars**. Those who once set the style in clothes now went naked; and those who owned property were now homeless... **The New City (Shahjahanabad) was turned into rubble**."*

🔗 **Remember Ch.7:** it was **this very invasion of 1739** that drove **Mughal painters into the Himalayan foothills**, founding the **Kangra school**. **The same event that destroyed a capital created a school of painting**. That cross-reference is exactly the kind of connection that makes an answer memorable.

★ **Ahmad Shah Abdali's fifth invasion is the third battle of Panipat, 1761** — where he destroyed the Marathas. **The two great powers contending for north India wrecked each other, and the British inherited the field**.

🎭 ★ Faction and humiliation

The empire was further weakened by **competition amongst different groups of nobles**, divided into **two major factions**:

Faction	Who
★ IRANIS	Nobles of Iranian descent
★ TURANIS	Nobles of Turkish descent

"For a long time, the later Mughal emperors were PUPPETS in the hands of either one or the other of these two powerful groups."

★ ★ The humiliation, stated plainly by NCERT:

Emperor	Fate
Farrukh Siyar (1713–1719)	★ ASSASSINATED
Alamgir II (1754–1759)	★ ASSASSINATED
Ahmad Shah (1748–1754)	★ BLINDED by his nobles
Shah Alam II (1759–1816)	★ BLINDED by his nobles

🎯 Two emperors murdered and two blinded by their own nobility, within fifty years. That single fact conveys the collapse of imperial authority more forcefully than any general statement — use it as evidence, not decoration.

2 ★ ★ The Successor States — Three Types

NCERT's material sorts into three categories, and **classifying them properly is what separates a good answer from a list**:

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| TYPE 1: OLD MUGHAL PROVINCES that became independent |
| Governors (subadars) and great zamindars consolidated |
| their authority. |
| *** AWADH | BENGAL | HYDERABAD *** |
| -> Founded by MUGHAL OFFICERS. Still formally recognised |
| the emperor. "Inherited from the inside." (Ch.4) |
+-----+
| TYPE 2: WATAN JAGIRS -- states that had always existed under |
| Mughal suzerainty and now asserted autonomy |
| *** THE RAJPUTS *** (Amber, Jodhpur, Mewar) |
+-----+
| TYPE 3: STATES SEIZED BY REBELLION against the Mughals |
| *** SIKHS | MARATHAS | JATS *** |
| -> "Seizing Independence" |
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★ NCERT explicitly names Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad as provinces where *subadars* and great zamindars consolidated authority. The chapter then details the Type 2 and Type 3 states.

3 ★★ The Rajputs

Fact	Detail
Their standing	Many Rajput kings, particularly of AMBER and JODHPUR , had served under the Mughals with distinction — in exchange they enjoyed considerable autonomy in their WATAN JAGIRS
The 18th-century move	These rulers attempted to extend their control over adjacent regions
★ The offices they claimed	The <i>subadari</i> of the rich provinces of GUJARAT and MALWA : Raja AJIT SINGH of JODHPUR held the governorship of GUJARAT ; SAWAI RAJA JAI SINGH of AMBER was governor of MALWA . These offices were renewed by Emperor Jahandar Shah in 1713
Territorial seizures	NAGAU R was conquered and annexed to the house of Jodhpur ; Amber seized large portions of BUNDI
★ The new capital	Sawai Raja Jai Singh founded his new capital at JAIPUR and was given the <i>subadari</i> of AGRA in 1722
⚠ The check	★ Maratha campaigns into Rajasthan from the 1740s put severe pressure on these principalities and CHECKED THEIR FURTHER EXPANSION
Mewar's exception	★ Many Rajput rulers accepted Mughal suzerainty, but MEWAR was the only Rajput state which defied it . Rana Pratap ascended the throne at Mewar in 1572 and stood his ground despite a series of envoys

🏰 Forts and observatories ★

- Many Rajput chieftains **built forts on hill tops** which became **centres of power** — housing **urban centres, palaces, temples, trading centres, water harvesting structures**. The **Chittorgarh fort** contained **talabs (ponds), kundis (wells), baolis (stepwells)**
- ★★ **Sawai Jai Singh, the ruler of Amber, constructed FIVE ASTRONOMICAL OBSERVATORIES** — one each at **DELHI, JAIPUR, UJJAIN, MATHURA and VARANASI**. Commonly known as the ★ **JANTAR MANTAR**, they had **various instruments to study heavenly bodies**

★★ **The Jantar Mantar is a high-frequency Prelims item and a great Mains detail.** The **five cities** are asked directly. It also makes an excellent point: in the middle of imperial collapse, a regional ruler was **funding astronomy** — evidence that the 18th century was not a cultural dark age but a period of **decentralised patronage** (exactly the Ch.7 argument about painting).

A 1732 Persian account of Jai Singh: "He was the governor of Agra for 12 years and of Malwa for 5 or 6 years. He possessed a large army, artillery and great wealth. **His sway extended from Delhi to the banks of the Narmada.**"*

4 ★★ Seizing Independence: THE SIKHS

Follow the arc from religious community (Ch.6) to sovereign state.

17th CENTURY : the organisation of the Sikhs into a POLITICAL COMMUNITY (Ch.6) "helped in REGIONAL STATE-BUILDING in the PUNJAB"

| Several battles fought by GURU GOBIND SINGH against
| Rajput and Mughal rulers, BEFORE AND AFTER the
| institution of the KHALSA in 1699

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1708 : Guru Gobind Singh dies

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BANDA BAHADUR leads the Khalsa in REVOLT against Mughal authority

- > *** declared SOVEREIGN RULE by STRIKING COINS in the name of GURU NANAK and GURU GOBIND SINGH ***
- > established their own administration BETWEEN THE SUTLEJ AND THE JAMUNA
- > CAPTURED 1715, EXECUTED 1716

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THE 18th CENTURY ORGANISATION

- Sikhs organised into bands called *** JATHAS ***; later *** MISLS ***
- Their combined forces = the grand army, *** DAL KHALSA ***
- The entire body met at AMRITSAR at BAISAKHI and DIWALI to take collective decisions -- "resolutions of the Guru", *** GURMATAS ***
- A system called *** RAKHI *** offered PROTECTION to cultivators on payment of a tax of *** 20 PER CENT of the produce ***

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THE IDEOLOGY : Guru Gobind Singh had inspired the Khalsa with the belief that their destiny was to rule -- *** "RAJ KAREGA KHALSA" ***

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Successful resistance FIRST to the Mughal governors, THEN to AHMAD SHAH ABDALI, who had seized the rich province of the Punjab and the SARKAR OF SIRHIND

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1765 : The Khalsa AGAIN declared sovereign rule by striking their own coin -- bearing THE SAME INSCRIPTION as in Banda Bahadur's time

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LATE 18th CENTURY : Sikh territories extended FROM THE INDUS TO THE JAMUNA but were DIVIDED under different rulers

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*** MAHARAJA RANJIT SINGH reunited these groups and established his capital at LAHORE in 1799 ***

★★ Note what "striking coins" means. Minting coinage is **the definitive assertion of sovereignty** in the Islamic-Persianate world (along with having the *khutba* read in one's name). By issuing coins **in the Gurus' names**, Banda Bahadur was making a **formal, legally legible claim to independent rule** — and doing it **twice, in 1710s and again in 1765, with the same inscription**, asserting continuity.

★ The *rakhi* system is also worth understanding, because it is state-building in miniature: **offer protection, charge 20%**. That is precisely what a state is — a protection service with a tax. **The Sikhs built a state from the revenue function upward.**

🌀 And the *gurmata* is a genuine **Polity crossover**: collective decisions taken by the assembled body at fixed festivals. Add it to your **Vajji sangha** → **Buddhist sangha** → **Chola sabha** lineage of Indian deliberative institutions (Class 6 Ch.5, Ch.6, Ch.9 and Class 7 Ch.2).

5 ★ ★ ★ THE MARATHAS

Shivaji and the foundation

Fact	Detail
Founder	★ CHHATRAPATI SHIVAJI MAHARAJ (1630–1680)
Born	To Shahji and Jija Bai at ★ SHIVNERI in 1630; guided by his mother and his guardian Dada Konddev
Nature of the state	"Another powerful regional kingdom to arise out of a sustained opposition to Mughal rule "
★ His support base	Powerful warrior families — ★ DESHMUKHS
★ His army's backbone	Groups of highly mobile, peasant-pastoralists — ★ KUNBIS
Early conquest	The occupation of JAVLI made him undisputed leader of the MAVALA highlands , paving the way for expansion
His method	★ Often resorted to GUERRILLA WARFARE ; his exploits against Bijapur and the Mughals made him a legendary figure
★ ★ His revenue system	An efficient administration supported by revenue collection based on ★ CHAUTH* and *SARDESHMUKHI

★ ★ The two taxes — learn the rates:

Tax	Rate	Meaning
★ CHAUTH	25 per cent of the land revenue claimed by zamindars	In the Deccan, collected by the Marathas
★ SARDESHMUKHI	9–10 per cent of the land revenue	Paid to the head revenue collector in the Deccan

💡 **Memory hook:** *chauth* from *chautha* = "a fourth" = 25%. The word tells you the rate.
Sardeshmukhi = the due of the *sardeshmukh*, the chief headman — 9–10%.

The Peshwas and expansion

Fact	Detail
After Shivaji's death	Effective power was wielded by a family of ★ CHITPAVAN BRAHMANAS who served Shivaji's successors as ★ PESHTHA (principal minister)
★ Capital	★ POONA became the capital of the Maratha kingdom
★ Military method	Under the Peshwas the Marathas developed a very successful military organisation . Their success lay in ★ BYPASSING the fortified areas of the Mughals , by RAIDING CITIES , and by engaging Mughal armies in areas where their SUPPLY LINES AND REINFORCEMENTS could be easily disturbed
Baji Rao I	Son of Peshwa Balaji Vishwanath ; a great general credited with expanding the Maratha kingdom beyond the Vindhya s; campaigns against Malwa, Bundelkhand, Gujarat and the Portuguese

★ ★ The expansion, 1720–1761:

1720s : MALWA and GUJARAT seized from the Mughals
 1730s : the Maratha king recognised as OVERLORD OF THE ENTIRE DECCAN PENINSULA, with the right to levy CHAUTH and SARDESHMUKHI in the whole region
 1737 : RAIDED DELHI
 then : frontiers expanded rapidly --
 NORTH -> Rajasthan and the Punjab
 EAST -> Bengal and Orissa
 SOUTH -> Karnataka, and the Tamil and Telugu countries

*** These were NOT FORMALLY INCLUDED in the Maratha empire, but were MADE TO PAY TRIBUTE as a way of accepting Maratha sovereignty. ***

⚠️ ★ ★ ★ Why Panipat was lost — the causal point

"Expansion brought enormous resources, BUT IT CAME AT A PRICE. These military campaigns also MADE OTHER RULERS HOSTILE towards the Marathas. As a result, THEY WERE NOT INCLINED TO SUPPORT THE MARATHAS during the THIRD BATTLE OF PANIPAT IN 1761."

★ ★ ★ This is the single most important analytical sentence in the chapter, and it is a ready-made Mains answer.

The Marathas expanded by **extracting tribute from rulers they did not absorb**. That produced **revenue but not allies** — every tributary was a resentful neighbour rather than a stakeholder. So when Ahmad Shah Abdali came in **1761**, the Marathas faced him **alone**.

🔗 **Contrast Akbar's policy directly (Ch.4): "defeating but not humiliating."** Akbar **absorbed** defeated Rajputs into the mansabdari with *watan jagirs* and marriage alliances, converting enemies into stakeholders. **The Marathas taxed where the Mughals had co-opted — and paid for it at Panipat.** That comparison, stated in two sentences, is worth serious marks.

🏠 ★ ★ Maratha administration — the part most people miss

"Alongside endless military campaigns, the Marathas developed an EFFECTIVE ADMINISTRATIVE SYSTEM as well."

Measure	Detail
Revenue	Once conquest was complete and rule secure, revenue demands were gradually introduced TAKING LOCAL CONDITIONS INTO ACCOUNT
Economy	★ Agriculture was encouraged and trade revived
★ The sardars	This gave Maratha chiefs (<i>sardars</i>) — ★ SINDHIA of GWALIOR, GAEKWAD of BARODA, BHONSLE of NAGPUR — the resources to raise powerful armies
★ Cities grew	Maratha campaigns into Malwa in the 1720s did not challenge the growth and prosperity of the region's cities. ★ UJJAIN expanded under SINDHIA's patronage and INDORE under HOLKAR's — "large and prosperous... important commercial and cultural centres"
★ New trade routes	Emerged within Maratha-controlled areas. The silk produced in the CHANDERI region found a new outlet in POONA. BURHANPUR , earlier on the Agra-Surat trade, expanded its hinterland to include Poona and Nagpur in the south and Lucknow and Allahabad in the east

★★ This section is the direct rebuttal to "the 18th century was a period of chaos and decline." Cities grew, trade routes multiplied, agriculture was encouraged, and revenue was assessed with local conditions in mind. **Economic life reorganised around new centres rather than collapsing.**

🔴 The sardar–city pairings are asked: Sindhia–Gwalior/Ujjain, Gaekwad–Baroda, Bhonsle–Nagpur, Holkar–Indore.

6 ★ The Jats

Fact	Detail
When	Consolidated power during the late seventeenth and eighteenth centuries
★ Under Churaman	Acquired control over territories west of Delhi ; by the 1680s they dominated the region between the two imperial cities of DELHI and AGRA . For a while they became the virtual custodians of the city of AGRA
Their economy	★ Prosperous agriculturists ; towns like PANIPAT and BALLABHGARH became important trading centres
★★ Under Suraj Mal	The kingdom of ★ BHARATPUR emerged as a strong state. He consolidated the Jat state at Bharatpur during 1756–1763 ; his territory included parts of modern eastern Rajasthan, southern Haryana, western Uttar Pradesh and Delhi . He built many forts and palaces — the famous ★ LOHAGARH fort at Bharatpur is regarded as one of the strongest in the region
★ After 1739	When Nadir Shah sacked Delhi , many of the city's notables took refuge in Bharatpur
Jawahir Shah	Suraj Mal's son; had 30,000 troops of his own and hired another 20,000 Maratha and 15,000 Sikh troops to fight the Mughals
★ Architecture	While the Bharatpur fort was built in a fairly traditional style, at ★ DIG the Jats built an elaborate GARDEN PALACE combining styles seen at AMBER and AGRA ; its buildings were modelled on architectural forms first associated with royalty under SHAH JAHAN

🎯 Two points worth extracting:

1. **Jawahir Shah hiring Maratha and Sikh troops** shows how fluid 18th-century politics was — these were **military labour markets**, not fixed national blocs. It's a useful corrective to reading the period as a clash of communities
2. **Dig's palace copying Shah Jahan's forms** is the Ch.7 argument again: **successor states inherited and reused Mughal cultural prestige** even while dismantling Mughal power

7 ★ ★ ★ Decline, or Reorganisation? — The Assessment

This is the question UPSC actually asks. Argue both sides.

"The 18th century was a period of DECLINE"	"The 18th century was a period of REORGANISATION"
Imperial administration broke down ; revenue stopped reaching Delhi	Successor states developed effective administrative systems taking local conditions into account
Two emperors assassinated, two blinded	Ujjain, Indore, Poona, Jaipur, Bharatpur grew as prosperous commercial and cultural centres
Nadir Shah (1739) and Abdali (five times, 1748–61) plundered at will	Agriculture encouraged, trade revived, NEW TRADE ROUTES emerged
Constant warfare; the Marathas isolated and broken at Panipat 1761	Jantar Mantar observatories built; Kangra and Rajput painting flourished (Ch.7)
The British seized eastern India by 1765	Regional languages and cultures consolidated (Ch.7)

★ ★ ★ The formulation that scores:

*"The eighteenth century saw not the collapse of governance but its **relocation** — from an imperial centre that could no longer collect revenue to regional states that could. What declined was **Mughal** authority, not Indian state capacity or economic life. The decisive weakness was not disorder but **disunity**: states that extracted tribute from one another rather than building alliances faced Ahmad Shah Abdali, and then the English East India Company, one at a time."*

🔗 **And that last clause is the bridge to Class 8.** The British did not defeat "India"; **they defeated a sequence of individually strong, mutually hostile regional states.** Panipat 1761 and Plassey 1757 belong to the same story.

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Period ★	1707 (Aurangzeb's death) → 1761 (third Panipat) ; British hold eastern India by 1765
Causes of crisis ★★	Deccan war; administrative breakdown; ★ <i>subadars* holding diwani + *faujdari</i> ; revenue remission declined ; peasant and zamindari revolts
Nadir Shah ★★	Ruler of Iran ; sacked Delhi in 1739 ; took the Peacock Throne
Ahmad Shah Abdali ★★	Afghan; invaded five times, 1748–1761
Factions ★	Iranis and Turanis
Emperors' fates ★	Farrukh Siyar and Alamgir II assassinated; Ahmad Shah and Shah Alam II blinded
Type-1 successor states ★	Awadh, Bengal, Hyderabad
Rajputs ★★	Ajit Singh (Jodhpur) → Gujarat; Sawai Jai Singh (Amber) → Malwa ; offices renewed 1713 ; Jaipur founded; subadari of Agra 1722 ; checked by Marathas from the 1740s
Mewar ★	The only Rajput state that defied Mughal suzerainty; Rana Pratap , throne 1572
Jantar Mantar ★★	Sawai Jai Singh ; five observatories — Delhi, Jaipur, Ujjain, Mathura, Varanasi
Banda Bahadur ★★	Revolt after 1708 ; struck coins in the Gurus' names; between Sutlej and Jamuna ; captured 1715, executed 1716
Sikh organisation ★★ ★	<i>jathas*</i> → <i>misl</i> s; <i>dal khalsa</i> ; <i>*gurmatas</i> at Amritsar on Baisakhi and Diwali ; <i>rakhi</i> = protection for 20% of produce
"Raj karega Khalsa" ★	The belief instilled by Guru Gobind Singh
Ranjit Singh ★★	Reunited the <i>misl</i> s; capital at LAHORE in 1799
Shivaji ★★	1630–1680 ; born at Shivneri ; deshmukhs and kunbis ; Javli, Mavala ; guerrilla warfare
Chauth / Sardeshmukhi ★★ ★	25% / 9–10% of land revenue
Peshwas ★★	Chitpavan Brahmanas ; capital POONA
Maratha expansion ★	Malwa & Gujarat by the 1720s ; overlords of the Deccan by the 1730s ; raided Delhi 1737
Panipat 1761 ★★ ★	Marathas unsupported because their campaigns had made other rulers hostile
Maratha sardars ★★	Sindhia–Gwalior (Ujjain), Gaekwad–Baroda, Bhonsle–Nagpur, Holkar–Indore
Jats ★	Churaman ; between Delhi and Agra ; Suraj Mal, Bharatpur, Lohagarh fort ; garden palace at DIG

Traps:

- "Nadir Shah invaded Bengal" → **FALSE**. He sacked **Delhi** (NCERT asks this as true/false)
- "Sawai Raja Jai Singh was the ruler of Indore" → **FALSE**. He ruled **Amber** and founded **Jaipur**; Indore was **Holkar's**
- "Chauth was 10% and sardeshmukhi 25%" → **REVERSED**. Chauth **25%**, sardeshmukhi **9–10%**
- "Poona was the Maratha capital from Shivaji's time" → It became the capital **under the Peshwas, in the eighteenth century**
- "The Marathas were defeated at Panipat because they were militarily weak" → **FALSE**. They were **isolated** — other rulers refused to support them

- **"Banda Bahadur founded the Khalsa" → FALSE. Guru Gobind Singh, 1699;** Banda led the revolt after 1708
- **"Ranjit Singh made Amritsar his capital" → FALSE. Lahore, 1799**

Mains

- ★★ ★ *"Examine the causes of the decline of the Mughal Empire."* — lead with the **structural** argument (fusion of *diwani* and *faujdari*, the **jagirdari crisis** from Ch.4), not with "weak successors"
- ★★ ★ *"The eighteenth century witnessed the reorganisation rather than the collapse of political and economic life in India."* Critically examine
- ★★ ★ *"The Marathas' method of expansion contained the cause of their defeat."* Discuss — tribute vs alliance; contrast with **Akbar's** policy
- ★★ **Prelude to colonialism:** how a subcontinent of strong-but-divided states enabled the Company's rise
- ★ **Polity crossover:** the ***gurmata*** as a deliberative institution

🔑 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Subadar / subadari	Provincial governor / governorship
Diwani	The office of revenue administration
Faujdari	The office of military administration
Ijaradari	Revenue farming — the right to collect revenue, sold to a contractor
Watan jagir	A ruler's hereditary homeland held as an assignment
Irani / Turani	The two noble factions — of Iranian / Turkish descent
Jatha	A Sikh band
Misl	A Sikh confederacy/unit
Dal Khalsa	The combined Sikh grand army
Gurmata	A "resolution of the Guru" — collective decision at Amritsar
Rakhi	Protection offered to cultivators for 20% of produce
Deshmukh	A powerful warrior/landholding family
Kunbi	Peasant-pastoralist; backbone of the Maratha army
Peshwa	The principal minister of the Maratha state
Chauth	25% of land revenue claimed by zamindars, collected by the Marathas
Sardeshmukhi	9–10% of land revenue paid to the head revenue collector
Sardar	A Maratha chief

📅 2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **1707 → 1761.** Aurangzeb's death to the third battle of Panipat; **by 1765 the British held eastern India.**
2. **The crisis:** Aurangzeb's **Deccan war** drained men and money; administration broke down; ★ ***subadars*** * ***came to hold diwani AND *faujdari***, giving them political, economic and military power; **revenue stopped reaching Delhi**; peasant and zamindari revolts **seized the region's resources.**

3. "Though the peasant reaps a harvest of gold, his lord does not see so much as a wisp of straw" — a **collection** failure, not a production failure.
4. **Nadir Shah of Iran sacked Delhi in 1739**, taking the **Peacock Throne**; **Ahmad Shah Abdali** raided **five times, 1748–61**.
5. **Irani and Turani factions** made emperors puppets — **two assassinated, two blinded**.
6. **Three kinds of successor state**: Mughal provinces gone independent (**Awadh, Bengal, Hyderabad**); **watan jagir** states (**Rajputs**); and states **seized by rebellion** (**Sikhs, Marathas, Jats**).
7. **Rajputs: Ajit Singh → Gujarat, Sawai Jai Singh → Malwa, Jaipur** founded, **Agra subadari 1722**; **checked by the Marathas from the 1740s**. **Mewar** alone had defied the Mughals. **Jai Singh built five Jantar Mantar observatories**.
8. **Sikhs**: after 1708, **Banda Bahadur** revolted and **struck coins in the Gurus' names** (captured 1715, executed 1716); the Sikhs organised into **jathas* and *misls**, combined as the **dal khalsa**, met at **Amritsar** for **gurmata**s, and ran the **rakhi** protection system at **20% of produce**; **Ranjit Singh** reunited them at **Lahore in 1799**.
9. **Marathas: Shivaji (1630–1680)** built the state on **deshmukhs** and **kunbis** with **guerrilla warfare** and the **chauth (25%) / sardeshmukhi (9–10%)** system; the **Chitpavan Brahmana Peshwas** ruled from **Poona**; expansion took **Malwa and Gujarat by the 1720s**, Deccan overlordship by the **1730s**, and **Delhi raided in 1737**.
10. ★ **They took tribute without absorbing anyone — so nobody helped them at Panipat in 1761**.
11. **But their administration worked**: revenue set by local conditions, **agriculture encouraged, trade revived**, **Ujjain (Sindhia)** and **Indore (Holkar)** flourished, and **new trade routes** linked Chanderi, Poona, Burhanpur, Nagpur, Lucknow and Allahabad.
12. **Jats: Churaman** took the Delhi–Agra tract; **Suraj Mal** built **Bharatpur** and the **Lohagarh fort**; the garden palace at **DIG** copied **Shah Jahan's** forms.
13. ★ **The century was a reorganisation, not a collapse — but a disunited one**, which is exactly what the East India Company needed.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. State whether true or false: (a) Nadir Shah invaded Bengal. (b) Sawai Raja Jai Singh was the ruler of Indore. (c) Guru Gobind Singh was the tenth Guru of the Sikhs. (d) Poona became the capital of the Marathas in the eighteenth century. → (a) False — **Delhi**. (b) False — **Amber**, founder of Jaipur. (c) True. (d) True.
2. *Chauth* and *sardeshmukhi* were respectively — → *25% and 9–10% of land revenue*.
3. Consider the following about Sikh organisation in the eighteenth century:
 1. Bands called *jathas* later became *misls*.
 2. Collective decisions taken at Amritsar were called *gurmata*s.
 3. Under *rakhi*, cultivators paid 20 per cent of their produce for protection. → *All three*.
4. Sawai Jai Singh's astronomical observatories were built at — → *Delhi, Jaipur, Ujjain, Mathura and Varanasi*.
5. Which best explains the Maratha defeat at Panipat in 1761? → *Their campaigns had made other rulers hostile, so they received no support*.
6. Consider the following pairs:

1. Sindhia — Gwalior 2. Gaekwad — Baroda 3. Holkar — Nagpur → 1 and 2 only. The **Bhonsles** held Nagpur; Holkar held **Indore**.

Mains style

7. Examine the structural causes of Mughal decline in the eighteenth century. **(250 words)**
8. "The eighteenth century saw the relocation of governance rather than its collapse." Critically examine. **(250 words)**
9. "The Maratha method of expansion contained within it the cause of their isolation at Panipat." Discuss, contrasting it with Mughal policy towards the Rajputs. **(250 words)**
10. Trace the transformation of the Sikhs from a religious community into a sovereign political power. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Why was combining *diwani* and *faujdari* fatal?
- Give the dates and outcomes of the Nadir Shah and Abdali invasions.
- Name the three types of successor state with examples.
- Explain *jatha*, *misl*, *dal khalsa*, *gurmata*, *rakhi*.
- State the rates of *chauth* and *sardeshmukhi*.
- Why did no one support the Marathas in 1761?
- Give three pieces of evidence that the 18th century was not simply a period of decline.